

Michigan

To save their grandparents' lake house from becoming a data center, a Dearborn girl and her grieving Yooper cousin must bridge their peninsula-sized rivalry, proving blood is thicker than the Mackinac Strait.

Michigan

In Honor of
The MacGregor Family

&

In Loving Memory of
Andrew "Andy" Van Otteren
March 17, 1994 - July 12, 2026
Tiffany Marie Emmert
April 29, 1996 - January 19, 2026
James Emmert
May 5, 1991 - January 19, 2026

Thanks to you all, David and countless others
love musical theatre and Michigan.

Michigan

SYNOPSIS

When their heartbroken grandpa is tricked into signing away the family lake house to data center developers, rival cousins Petoskey and Lulu must put aside their Upper and Lower Peninsulas differences during a family reunion. To buy back the home, they must trade Petoskey's late father's treasured heirloom (a heart-shaped Petoskey necklace with an elk symbol) which Lulu lost in Elk Lake years ago. Petoskey, a native fossil that reveals its true pattern when wet, serves as a metaphor for hidden grief and emotional depth.

Michigan is inspired by David Quang Pham's upbringing and the MacGregors who invite him to their Elk Rapids lake house on Harbor Days since being roommates with their family member Lukas Jacob in 2014. He wrote this musical as a love letter to his family and communities as well as loved ones lost to suicide on our home Mitten.

WHY NOW?

Michigan champions human connection, creativity, and nature against the rising tide of technological isolation, symbolized by the threat of replacing a historic lake house with an AI data center. By centering its narrative on the long-term impact of suicide and collective loss, the play directly addresses our modern mental health crisis, offering a vital roadmap for healing through open communication and community. Furthermore, it uses localized science and folklore to bridge regional cultural divides, reminding audiences to protect both the natural environments and the shared, real-world heritages that keep us rooted.

Michigan is the homeliness of *Oklahoma* meets the whimsiness of *Waitress* meets the folksiness of *Bright Star*.

Michigan

THEMES

Collective Grief and Emotional Healing

The story explores the long-term impact of grief after Petey's suicide and Grandma Milly's death, demonstrating how silence fractures families while open communication fosters generational healing.

Community versus Technology

The central conflict pits a warm hand-made tradition against cold corporate greed, by keeping AI data centers from erasing local heritage, such as the family's lake house.

Geographic and Cultural Disconnection

The narrative highlights how families can become polarized by peninsulas, symbolized by the physical and emotional barrier of the Mackinac Bridge separating the Upper and Lower Peninsula identities. The story leans into subcultures, contrasting Yooper (Upper Peninsula) against suburban Dearborn/Lower Peninsula dynamics.

Belonging and Identity

Through Lulu's competitive drive to outshine her cousins, the musical examines the painful adolescent struggle to fit into a Midwest family dynamic and find one's own sense of worth.

Nature, Folklore, and Science Literacy

By embedding paleontology into the musical numbers, the narrative uses the natural history of the Petoskey stone fossil to teach environmental appreciation and show how memories attach themselves to physical landscapes.

Michigan

The Immigrant Experience and Cultural Harmonization

This manifests through multiple layers, such as Shelby marrying an Arab man, Jasper Tran's Vietnamese restaurant (Banh MiMichigan), and Jasper's realization that his refugee family stayed united across continents while local families are divided by peninsulas. It deals heavily with how different minority communities interact within the Midwest.

Economic Displacement and Xenophobia

The backstory reveals the harsh realities of blue-collar job loss during the recession. It directly addresses the displaced anger that can arise from automated or immigrant replacement (Petey being fired and replaced by a migrant worker), showing the tragic intersection of economic desperation, racial tension, and family fallout.

The Power of Collective Memory and Shared Artistry

The family's century-old Model T, their decades of eccentric, hand-made parade costumes, and the town's ultimate rally around them showcase art and "weirdness" as a mechanism for survival. It emphasizes that humanity defeats artificial optimization through shared, messy, authentic creativity.

Michigan

PLOT SUMMARY

Michigan is a folksy musical dramedy set on a family reunion where two isolated cousins must settle their regional differences to save their grandparents' lake house from being demolished for a data center. The themes explore silent grief, open communication to heal, cultural disconnection of the peninsulas, and what it means to be a Michigander. While the musical is told in a partially non-linear narrative, the following is the chronological order of events that happen in the musical.

Elderly couples, Willy and Milly Vandam, live in Elk Rapids on the north tip of the Lower Peninsula. They have four adult children – Cherry, Perry, Shelby, and the only son Petey and several grandchildren. Every August, their lake house lodges them for the annual Harbor Days. They are known for their century-old Model T Ford and wearing themed costumes for the parade and winning every Most Creative Award (“The Mitten”).

In 2008, Petey lives with his pregnant wife Lizzie in the Upper Peninsula. His childhood friend is Jasper Tran, whose family runs Banh Mlchigan, a Vietnamese restaurant in Elk Rapids. On a swim, Petey jokingly promises they name their kid after the first rock he finds which is a heart-shaped Petoskey with an elk symbol. Soon, his job fires him and replaces him with an Arab migrant, and he gets in a fight with his younger sister Shelby for marrying one. During a storm, he drives off the Mackinac Bridge to save their house on his life insurance. The investigators give Liz his hearty Petoskey. Following his death, Liz refuses to cross the bridge to attend family gatherings (“The Greatest Thing in Life”). And Harbor Day mornings felt hollow without goofy Petey to wake them up with his Mitten Song until his son Petoskey was old enough to wear his mittens (“Sleep In”).

For Harbor Days, Petey’s sisters take turns driving Petoskey to Elk Rapids then Milly drives him home. Every time he crosses the Mackinac Bridge, Petey’s spirit sings. And Jasper becomes Petoskey’s godfather (“Yooper”). But his bright cousin Lulu Abughoush is a bully. She envies the praise he gets from his rare stone findings on their swims. In 2019, she drops his heirloom into Elk Lake, severing his spiritual ties to his dad (“Above and Beyond”). Then in 2020, Grandma Milly passes away. Overcome with grief, Grandpa Willy leaves his garden unattended and is manipulated by data center developer Charlie into signing away the deed. The family skips the 2020 and 2021 reunions.

In 2022, 13-year-old Petoskey returns with his mom for the first time since Petey’s death to honor Milly. They drive the long way through Wisconsin. Jasper helps Petoskey, Lulu, and the other kids set up camp and go canoeing with them. He often takes some of their snacks as a form of a “dad tax.” The aunties take even more with the “mom tax” (“Dad Tax”). From Willy, they soon discover Charlie's plot to sell the neighborhood.

Charlie tours the home and sees a photo of toddler Petoskey and his hearty stone. It is worth more than the whole neighborhood. Liz promises to trade it for the deed. They have a day to find the necklace at the bottom of Elk Lake (“Afford Anything”).

Michigan

Conveniently, Jasper and Aunt Perry run a scuba diving company but could not find it ("Bottom Up"). The next few nights, Petoskey and Lulu witness deer by the bonfire. He wishes to see his father while she wishes to beat Petoskey in this year's rock collection ("Dearborn"). The next day, Perry teaches fossils to the kids ("Fossil in the Stones"). Lulu separates from the group and discovers a deer dropping off the hearty Petoskey necklace and other rare stones on the shore ("The Great Lakes Ballet").

For the Harbor Days parade, cousin Jacob Jacob, a Broadway actor, is the Master of Ceremony. So, the 2022 theme is theatre shows. Petoskey plays Edward Bloom from *Big Fish* while Lulu plays Evan Hansen. Before marching, Lulu reveals her rare stone findings to the family. To spite Petoskey, she smashes his father's necklace, unaware it was their last chance to fulfill the deal with Charlie and save the lake house. The parade goes wrong as Petoskey beats up Lulu, disqualifying them from the awards for the first time ("Fraudway"). After a lecture, he runs away ("Kick Rocks").

In the following act, the family searches for Petoskey while Lulu visits Banh Michigan to look for him ("Petoskey"). Jasper shares that his refugee family stayed united despite continents dividing them. The Vandams are only divided by peninsulas. He also revisits a time when a Lebanese family bought out his family's restaurant, but did not resort to blame as Petey had. Lulu realizes where Petoskey most likely will be: the Mackinac Bridge ("North South East West").

They drive up to find him. She offers the broken stone as a truce, but he tosses it into the water ("Rock Bottom"). This causes the bridge to fog up where his father's ghost emerges as a giant elk. Petey shares that stones are special only when rocks are packed together. Like family, rocks come and go to leave a mark ("Family in the Stones"). In the Model T, Liz arrives at the bridge for the first time since Petey's death. They have a brief reunion as lovers once more before finding Petoskey ("Spirits Under the Bridge").

They return to Harbor Days fair on time. Charlie is exhibiting the new data center models with other developers. Petoskey offers the Model T which Charlie scoffs but is interested in. Jasper then offers his restaurant. The Vandams return with decades of themed costume while Charlie shows how "better" AI is. But the town rallies for this authentically creative and weird family, against artificial intelligence's goal of turning lakes into data centers. Charlie and the developers refuse and steal the Model T, causing the town to chase after them. She drives it off the Charlievoix bridge, then gets thrown into an asylum by Traverse City. All fraudulent contracts are declared void as one party is declared insane ("Leave No Stones Unturned").

Fourteen years later, Willy passes away. Petoskey and Lulu buy and fix the lake house. For the 2037 Harbor Days which celebrates 200 years of statehood, the theme is Pure Michigan where the Vandam family resembles the state's best ("Michigan").

Michigan

CAST OF CHARACTERS

THE VANDAM FAMILY

PETOSKEY VANDAM is a 13-year-old farm boy from Skandia and the goofiest of Willy and Milly's grandchildren. Besides his mom Liz, the only connection to his extended family happens on Harbor Days in Elk Rapids. He never met his deceased dad. To honor Petey, his son wears his heart-shaped Petoskey necklace with an elk symbol and awakens folks with his Mitten Song.

LIZZIE VANDAM is Petoskey's mother and narrator from Skandia. After her husband Petey's suicide in 2008, she stops crossing the Mackinac Bridge to attend Harbor Days and all family gatherings. Liz is a proud farm girl Yooper.

PETEY VANDAM is Petoskey's goofy father, Liz's husband, and Willy and Milly's only son of four children. Every morning on Harbor Days, he would be the first to get up, wear mittens, and bang things to wake everyone up. During the recession, his blue-collar shipyard job fires him and replaces him with an Arab migrant, leading him to get in a fight with his younger sister Shelby for marrying one. He would drive off the Mackinac Bridge to save their house with his life insurance. His ghost would visit Petoskey whenever he crosses the bridge, and he hopes Liz would visit Mackinac someday.

CHERRY JACOB is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's oldest sister in Grand Rapids. She arranges the theme and costumes for the annual Harbor Days parade.

PERRY VANDAM is Petoskey's aunt and Petey's older sister in Lansing. With science on her campy mind, she runs a scuba diving company with Jasper.

SHELBY ABOUGHOUH is Petoskey's aunt, Petey's little sister, and Lulu's mother who lives in Dearborn. She is an automotive worker for Ford Motor Company. As the sister who broke the mold by falling in love with an Arab, she and Petey had a tumultuous relationship. She tries to respect Petoskey.

LULU ABOUGHOUH is a 13-year-old city girl from Dearborn and the brightest of Willy and Milly's grandkids. Despite going above and beyond, she and her mom Shelby feel out of place. She tries to outshine her cousin Petoskey by finding more rare stones on their family reunion swims. In Arabic, her name means "pearl."

Michigan

JACOB JACOB is Cherry's son who is a successful Broadway actor in New York City. He is the Master of Ceremony for the 2022 Harbor Days.

MILLY VANDAM is Petoskey's bold grandmother and inventor. She invented the automatic toilet. With Willy, she owns a house by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids.

WILLY VANDAM is Petoskey's chill grandfather and gardener. With Milly, he owns a lake house by Elk Lake in Elk Rapids. Grieving Milly's death in 2020, he leaves the garden unattended and accidentally signs away the deed.

ELK RAPIDS RESIDENTS

JASPER TRAN is Petey's resourceful childhood friend and Petoskey's godfather who runs the Vietnamese restaurant, *Banh Mi*chigan, a scuba diving company with Aunt Perry, and a golf course for the heck of it. As a teen, he once looked down on the Arab community when a Lebanese family bought out his family's previous struggling restaurant. After Petey's passing with the last memory of him being his prejudice towards Arabs for "stealing American jobs," he vows to help migrants no matter what.

CHARLIE is the sketchy CEO of Turkey Ventures whose mission is to turn the Elk Lake neighborhood into a data center. She sees the Vandam family's hands-on creativity as inferior to the efficiency of artificial intelligence. Petoskey describes her as a turkey vulture.

Michigan

MUSICAL NUMBERS

ACT I

1. Overture / The Mitten Song
2. The Greatest Thing in Life Company
3. Sleep In Everyone but Petey
4. Yooper Petoskey
5. Above and Beyond Lulu, Shelby, Kids
6. Dad Tax Jasper, Vandam Aunties, Kids
7. Afford Anything Charlie, Realtors
8. Bottom-Up Petoskey, Jasper, Perry
9. Dearborn (Dear Deer) Petoskey, Lulu
10. Fossil in the Stones Perry, Kids
11. The Great Lakes Ballet Company
12. Fraudway Company
13. Kick Rocks The Vandams

ACT II

14. Petoskey Company
15. North South East West Lulu, Jasper
16. Rock Bottom Petoskey, Lulu
17. Family in the Stones Petey, Petoskey
18. Spirits Under the Bridge Lizzie, Petey
19. Leave No Stones Unturned Charlie, The Vandams, Residents
20. Michigan Company

👉 “Fossil in the Stones” is a David Quang Pham signature science song teaching paleontology.